All of the strategies we've discussed here require a little organization and planning to set up efficiently. But when done well, they can lead to significantly faster and more scalable automated acceptance criteria, which in turn leads to a faster build and release process.

12.6 Summary

In this chapter you learned about the role of BDD in the build and deployment process:

- Your executable specifications need to be part of an automated build process.
- Automated executable specifications can be run on a CI server to provide faster and more reliable feedback than could be achieved with manual testing alone.
- Automated executable specifications are an essential part of any CI process.
- CI can also be used to ensure that a project's living documentation is always up to date and easily available.
- You can speed up automated acceptance criteria by running them in parallel, either on a single machine or across several machines.
- Selenium Grid is a specialized tool that makes it easy to run WebDriver-based tests in parallel on multiple machines.

If you've made it this far, congratulations! We've covered a lot of material in this book, going right across the spectrum from requirements discovery to automated tests and living documentation. I'll try to distill all that we've discussed into a few short paragraphs.

12.7 Final words

BDD is based on a few simple principles, many of which are closely aligned with broader Agile principles:

- Describe behavior, don't specify solutions.
- Discover the behavior that will deliver real business value.
- Use conversations and examples to explore what a system should do.

Conversation and collaboration is key. As Liz Keogh is fond of saying, "Having conversations is more important than capturing conversations is more important than automating conversations." In the first part of this book, you learned a number of techniques and approaches that can help facilitate these conversations and capture useful examples in an unambiguous form.

But automation has huge value too. Once you're satisfied that you've understood a requirement sufficiently, automation is where the rubber meets the road and the examples turn into executable specifications. At the high-level requirements level, you learned how to express examples in a form that can be easily automated with tools like Cucumber and JBehave, and how to automate them in a clean, robust, and sustainable way. In chapter 10 you saw how writing executable specifications at the unit-testing level really is a no-brainer. And automation is the cornerstone of the continuous integration and delivery strategies we looked at in this chapter.